as the village head had been traditionally. The British policy was geared toward generating enough revenue to pay for the colonial administration of Burma. Tax collection was very structured and this led to the economic dislocation and land alienation, especially in times of hardship. Numerous impoverished peasants would end up defaulting on loans and ultimately lose their land. This also led to exploitation by moneylender immigrants from India known as Chettiyars.

The Burmese population felt that the British did not attempt to mitigate the situation, causing further frustration within the peasant communities. One of the initial responses from the Burmese was the formation of village associations to protect the interest of the peasants. The associations did not trust the colonial authorities and called for boycotts as well as social pressure to help the nationalist cause. Citizens were discouraged from collaborating with the colonial authorities through campaigns of intimidation and ostracization. These decisions led to harsh reprisals from the colonial administration. The police presence was increased and numerous groups were outlawed.

The anticolonial nationalistic struggle impacted every aspect of Burmese society. The economic and social structure of Burma was forever changed. The issue of minority relations as well as Buddhism played a significant role in the nationalist movement. As with most anticolonial struggles, political concepts from the West helped to shape the direction of the particular movements. Factional struggles at times hindered the advancement of the agenda. The issue of whether to take a more traditional or modern direction in the struggle was central for several decades. Ultimately, the Japanese helped to settle the question with their actions in Asia. The modern and more secular Thakin faction would carry the movement through World War II.